

HC HANDBOOK

#professionalism

Follow established guidelines to present yourself and your work products professionally.

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Defining the HC

Pitch

Have you decided intentionally, whether or not you will show up professionally?

Paragraph Description

Part of effective communication involves presenting yourself and your work in an appropriate and professional manner. To communicate effectively, consider the norms for presenting yourself to others, including tone, forms of address, and the use of slang or informal speech. Always proofread written work for errors, properly attribute quotations, ideas, data and other sources, and follow conventional practices regarding attribution and formatting for the type of communication you are crafting. Different academic disciplines have different formatting conventions, and it is important to use the expected standards. More broadly, ensure that your approach to communication, whether verbal or written, meets or surpasses the expectations relevant to the context.



Categorization

Habit of Mind | Multimodal Communications | Using Language

Cornerstone Introduction

Class: Multimodal Communications | Semester One

Unit: Close Reading

Big Question: How does language shape and represent reality?

General Example

Your new marketing firm has submitted a proposal to a chain of grocery stores that is seeking a fresh approach to its branding. Before you submitted your proposal, you asked several people to proofread it, verified design and font choices were kept consistent throughout, ensured figures and images were readable, formatted all titles and subtitles uniformly, and took great care that every aspect of it was presented according to the highest professional standards for your field. You made sure to properly attribute any information about behavioral economics research to the authors of the respective articles, using proper APA-style in-text citations and adding a bibliography. The grocery chain's CEO later remarked that he was very impressed by the professionalism of your proposal, noting that it reflected well on your attention to detail, honesty, and interest in the project.

Footnote: *Using colleagues to help detect mistakes that could be missed in one's self-proofreading, reviewing all formatting and design choices that might have been changed throughout the writing process, and adhering to the field's professional standards contributed to the overall assessment of the proposal. All non-original information was properly attributed to its original source in APA-style to abide by the conventions of the field.*

Is it this HC?

Is #professionalism the right HC? If the answer to the following questions is yes, #professionalism could be useful:

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1. Are you presenting your work or yourself in a professional context?

2. Are you considering the proper way to present yourself to others?
3. Have you noticed examples of implicit professional norms that you're using to inform your presentation of your work?

Consult the following table listing possible related HCs.

The following HC might apply if the work:	
#expression	- evaluates and utilizes nonverbal communication. #professionalism norms often inform what elements of #expression are most appropriate and effective.
#audience	tailors work products to the intended audience, helpful to understand what #professionalism looks like to the audience.
#context	- situates a work in its appropriate context for analysis or argumentation. #context often greatly informs #professionalism norms.
#sourcequality	analyzes and vets sources to ensure quality and credibility standards are met.
#evidencebased	analyzes and utilizes evidence to advance an argument.
#critique	evaluates how social norms/dynamics influence established professional guidelines.

Self Study

Try answering the questions on your own before checking the example answers.

👉 **Is there one correct grammar and spelling convention to follow?**

Answer: No. Across the world, grammar and spelling conventions differ. However, consistency and intentionality are key. You must know which convention you are following and stick to it. For example, the sentence “Red is my favorite color out of the colours of the rainbow” would not be acceptable because the same word is spelled differently in the same sentence. Although both spellings are correct, the inconsistency lacks professionalism and thoughtfulness.

👉 **How do you know which citation style to follow?**

Answer: If it is an assignment, carefully read the directions: your professor will likely instruct the appropriate citation style. However, if there are no directions regarding citations, you need to know what the field-specific citation norms are for your work. For example, psychological studies are cited in APA format, so if you are writing an argumentative paper about psychological phenomena, APA is your best bet. However, in other contexts, different styles are expected.

👉 **What are some examples of different citation styles?**

Answer:

(Note that this list is not exhaustive)

- APA (American Psychological Association)
 - This style is often used in Education, Psychology, and Sciences.
- MLA (Modern Language Association)
 - Works in the Humanities often use this style.

- Chicago/Turabian
 - This style is generally used in Business, History, and the Fine Arts.
- AMA (American Medical Association)
 - This is the standard style for works regarding Medicine.

👉 Which citation is which style?

Answer:

- Bologna, C. (2019, October 31). Why some people with anxiety love watching horror movies. HuffPost.
https://www.huffpost.com/entry/anxiety-love-watching-horror-movies_1_5d277587e4b02a5a5d57b59e
 - This is APA format.
- Bologna, Caroline. "Why Some People with Anxiety Love Watching Horror Movies." HuffPost, 31 Oct. 2019, www.huffpost.com/entry/anxiety-love-watching-horror-movies_1_5d277587e4b02a5a5d57b59e.
 - This is MLA format.

👉 How does one present themselves professionally?

Answer: Presenting yourself well in a professional setting means understanding what is expected of you. In some contexts, it is professional to wear formal dress; in others, doing so would make you seem uneducated and stuffy. So, after determining what professional attire looks like in the context of your work, make an intentional decision to follow those norms or break them. If you are on a virtual call where your background is visible, ensure you know what is in the background and what implications they send to the viewer. Professionalism is integrated with intentionality; understand your surroundings and the audience's expectations, and make professional decisions from there.

👉 **Does this HC imply that one should always follow established guidelines for professionalism?**

Answer: Not necessarily! The point of this HC is not to mandate that people mindlessly follow rules and norms, but rather, to be thoughtful of them, and then be deliberate in how you either follow or disrupt norms after weighing the pros and cons. This HC is broad enough to encompass deeply thinking about what it means to be professional in a given instance and how you want to follow that, or not, and why. This might depend on your personal relationship and experiences with the standards of professionalism in the given context and will require integrating other HCs, such as the bias or ethics HCs.

💡 Applying the HC

Guided Reflection

- Have you followed assignment instructions carefully and precisely?
- Have you investigated what the style guide requires?
- Have you explored field-specific norms regarding professionalism?
- Are grammar and punctuation rules followed consistently?
- Has your work been proofread and run through Grammarly for revisions?
- Have you explained your non-obvious choices in presenting and tailoring your work to a specific field?
- If you have broken professional norms, have you thoroughly explained why you made that choice and why it was effective?
- Are you thoughtfully and appropriately presenting yourself as the creator of a work product?
- Is your spelling consistent and correct?
- Are all your sources cited in the appropriate format?

Common Pitfalls

- The application fails to follow assignment instructions precisely.
- The application does not have a consistent format.

- No time was left for robust edits based on resources like Grammarly and peer review.
- Field-specific professional norms were not investigated, or false assumptions were made based on other fields.
- Inconsistencies appear in spelling, punctuation, or grammar.
- Sources are cited inconsistently or improperly according to the field-specific norms.
- The application neglects professional norms and fails to address why that choice was made.
- The application fails to showcase and justify deliberate style and formatting choices.

Applying the HC at Minerva

When creating any work, this HC will help you think deliberately about the field-specific professional norms and help you decide whether or not you should follow those norms.

Some examples of applications include:

- When writing a paper, it is essential to check assignment instructions carefully and format your paper by referring to a style guide that matches the instructions. Beyond this, you should also consider formatting, style, and conventions that you've observed in the context of other written work you've studied for that class. Each discipline has its own norms, and being attentive to them will help you tailor your work to the nuanced expectations of each professional environment. Deviations from formatting requirements should be discussed with your instructor and justified in the HC footnote.
- When delivering a presentation, whether live or recorded, you should use **#audience** to help you research the professional expectations of your audience and then tailor things like your background, attire, props, use of slides, etc. to that professional environment. For assignments in which you are teaching a class, or a section of a class, pay close attention to lesson plan formatting guidelines.
- Under this HC, Minerva students learn what being professional means for our context at Minerva. As you've seen in this handbook, this includes footnoting, following assignment instructions, citing sources appropriately, showing up to class ready to engage and participate, behaving according to certain

guidelines, etc. These norms are important to set community expectations. However, if a particular instance arose where a student wanted to explain why they did not follow specific guidelines for an assignment, or behaved a certain way in class, and grounded it in ideas about different norms for the given audience, that would be a very welcome application!

- Showcasing deliberate style and formatting choices makes for a good application of this HC. Here are some footnote snippets that demonstrate non-trivial thought toward presentation:
 - I opted for a narrower spacing than conventional APA to prevent the document from being too many pages long, and ensure that my figure/table titles and captions fit on the same page as the corresponding element. Plus, single-spacing is commonly used in other formatting conventions and usually followed in published technical research papers.
 - In my appendix, I used a Google Doc extension that makes code look more like it was written in a code editor. By using a monospace font with different colors for different syntaxes, like keywords, variables, and comments, I made the code more readable and reflective of the correct indentation.
 - I used a Latex compiler instead of a generic text editor like Google Docs to format equations professionally. This helped me better align expressions in multi-line calculations.

Applying the HC Outside of Minerva

- We regularly apply #professionalism when we adapt to subtle and often unspoken norms about how we interact with others in varied professional contexts. When you attend an awards ceremony, how you dress and what kinds of things you say in acceptance speeches depends on the professional context you're entering. If you're attending the Grammys, professionalism may look like stepping out of your comfort zone with a bold and stylish outfit and graciously supporting Grammy winners whether or not you agree with their merit. However, professional norms could be quite the opposite in a political debate. Professionalism may look like blending in with a plain suit, but

standing out by voicing your opposing views in heated debate.

- Sometimes, professional groups take pride in avoiding traditional professional norms. For example, you will likely see people in highly casual clothes at an evolutionary biology conference. Casual dress is a field-specific norm of such conferences. If one did not research what is considered professional, they might show up in a conventionally formal suit and tie, making themselves look uneducated and unprepared. Therefore, researching field-specific norms and avoiding assumptions about professionalism is always recommended.
- Professionalism is commonly perceived as the practice of exhibiting responsibility, integrity, accountability, and excellence within a professional setting. This encompasses the utilization of suitable language, tone, and attire, as well as presenting oneself and one's work in a competent and ethical manner. However, a critical examination of the established norms of professionalism is imperative. For example, if working with an American organization, it's likely that norms are predominantly formulated by individuals steeped in Western culture, thereby reflecting a white, Western-centric worldview.

Without deliberate instruction and contemplation on the origins of these standards, following them may inadvertently perpetuate a Western-centric cultural and social code. In some cases, this could create an unsafe or discriminatory environment for certain individuals if not addressed. It is vital to acknowledge and appreciate the diverse professional customs across different cultures and foster an understanding that professionalism can embody a spectrum of behaviors and practices, mirroring the diversity of an organization's individuals and their global cultures.

- Van Halen and M&Ms: When Van Halen was touring, they were famous for the detailed contract they would sign with venues where they performed. One specific element of the contract was that their dressing room had to be furnished with a bowl of M&Ms, with all of the brown ones removed. If the venue did not comply with the request, they would forfeit their payment for the

show. People typically interpreted this as a random prima-donna rock-star power move. However, they had a specific reason for including this requirement in their contracts.

Van Halen's shows involved a lot of pyrotechnics and elaborate electrical equipment. Other parts of the contract included details about wiring and positioning of various equipment. It was critically important for all of those instructions to be precisely followed. The problem is, a lot of that stuff is hard to check. You would have to look very closely at every single wire to make sure it was the appropriate gauge. Whether or not there are brown M&Ms in the dressing room is not important at all, but it is easy to check. The bowl of M&Ms served as a proxy, telling the band whether or not the venue had read the contract carefully and taken it seriously. If there were M&Ms in the dressing room with the brown ones removed, they felt they could trust that the stage had been set up correctly. If not, they knew they should go out and double check everything before the show.

Spelling and grammar are the brown M&Ms of a scientific paper. Every paper makes claims about the procedures they followed – how they collected and analyzed the data. It is very difficult, often impossible, for the reader to verify those claims. When the authors say they put 10mL of solution into each tube, how do we know they did not put in 9 or 11? Did they really incubate the culture for 30 minutes at 25 degrees? Was their thermometer calibrated? Did they remove it exactly when they were supposed to? Or was it 32 minutes at 26 degrees?

We can not independently verify many of a paper's claims. However, we can see whether or not they paid attention to details like punctuation and formatting. If your writing shows a high degree of attention to all of the fine details, the reader is more likely to believe that you applied that same level of attention to detail to the science itself.

Key Resources

- Minerva Academic Team. (2024). Cornerstone Summer Preparation Writing Resources.

<https://my.minerva.edu/academics/curriculum/foundation-year/cornerstone-summer-preparation/resources/writing-resources/>

- Relevant guides pertaining to aspects of #professionalism include the ones about grammar, formatting, and citations. There's also an APA template linked from this page.
- Purdue University. (2023). *Apa Sample Paper*. APA Sample Paper - Purdue OWL® - Purdue University.
https://owl.purdue.edu/owl/research_and_citation/apa_style/apa_formattin
 - This resource provides an APA formatted sample paper and specifies formatting conventions for professional papers.
- MyBib Contributors. (2018a, July 13). MyBib – A New FREE APA, MLA, Harvard Bibliography Generator. MyBib.com.
<https://www.mybib.com/>
 - This is a great resource for generating citations for specific styles.
- University of Pittsburgh. (2018). LibGuides: Citation Styles: APA, MLA, Chicago, Turabian, IEEE: Home. Libguides.com.
<https://pitt.libguides.com/citationhelp>
 - This source gives examples of how to cite various types of sources in different styles.
- Episode 1 – Knowledge Equity Lab. (n.d.). Retrieved October 20, 2023, from <https://knowledgeequitylab.ca/podcast/ep1/>

The Bias of 'Professionalism' Standards (SSIR). (2019).

Retrieved November 16, 2023, from

https://ssir.org/articles/entry/the_bias_of_professionalism_standards

- These resources provide more context on the biases commonly underlying professionalism guidelines and reflect on the importance of appreciating diverse professional customs.